



**RESCUE MISSION:** Search operations are on to locate the missing Greyhounds commandos

# A DEADLY AMBUSH

The killing of 35 crack Greyhounds commandos deals a severe blow to the anti-Maoist operations in Andhra Pradesh as well as in its neighbouring states

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

It is a stunning blow to the elite Greyhounds commando force of Andhra Pradesh. Having made a glorious record in anti-Maoist operations in the state as well as in neighbouring Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh and Orissa to emerge as a role model for other forces, few would have imagined that the compact and competent force of 2,470 men would lose 35 of the commandos to an ambush. But the enemy caught them napping, when a team of 55 commandos accompanied by two sub-inspectors, three home guards and two Orissa police constables along with a three-men crew were returning on a motor launch from a combing operation in a remote corner of the Malkanagiri district of Orissa.

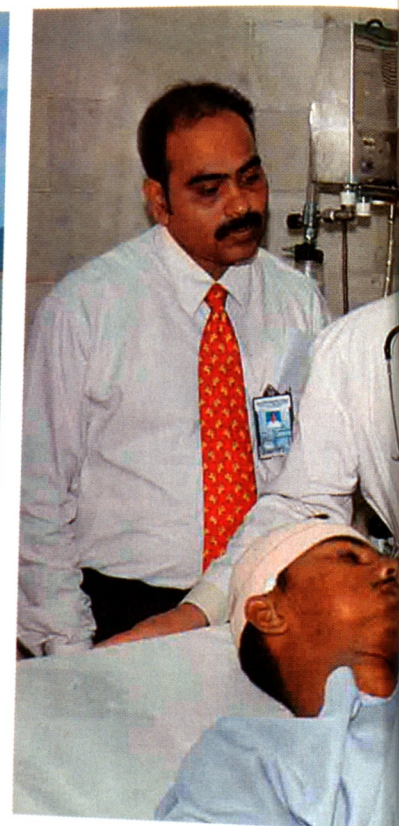
Seizing the advantage of the camouflage in thickly-vegetated hillocks flanking the Balmela reservoir on the Sileru river, the well-armed Maoists rained rockets and bullets on the commandos, some of whom were lazing on the deck, using light machine guns and

AK-47s. At first, a few of them got on to their feet to return the fire but soon the bullet-ridden boat capsized. While many went down with it into the 40-m-deep reservoir, others swam only to be pursued by the Maoists on a paddle boat. Of the 29 who swam to safety, nine were admitted to a hospital with injuries including gunshot wounds.

The Greyhounds commandos were lured into a well-planned trap considering that the Maoists used rocket launchers and light machine guns in the attack. The men had been involved in combing operations on a tip-off that the Maoists were organising a conclave on the Andhra-Orissa border. Fully aware that the commandos will come in large numbers, the left wing extremists lay in wait to attack them when they were returning by boat. The commandos fell in a clumsy manner contrary to their reputa-

tion. Investigations have revealed that though the Greyhounds had mooted the idea of travelling by the boat, it was the Orissa Police who had booked it on June 25, four days ahead of the attack, and had possibly indicated that it was to be used by the commandos. The false leads coupled with sensitive information about commando movements may have been passed on to Maoist supporters, making them easy targets.

The sudden loss of experienced commandos, many of whose bodies are yet to be found, has only been compounded by the loss of weapons they were carrying like light machine guns, AK-47s, self-loading and Insar rifles. Consequently, 300 Greyhound commandos, 120 CRPF personnel and 65 men of the Special Operations Group of the Orissa Police were deployed to provide a security



It is believed that the sensitive information about commando movements was passed on to the Maoists.